

Chapter 7: Hope

Kraekon, Modern Day

Kraekon couldn't hate the rain. On days like these, he wished that the darkness was gone; there was just something so peaceful about the rain drops pattering on the ground that drowned out all the worries in his mind. It washed away his fears and made the world seem smaller, like there was no one else but him and the rain—no one to perform for. If the rain weren't so dangerous, he imagined he would just take a walk through the streets—stare at the lights of the city reflecting off the water, listen to the steady downpour, and feel safe and alone.

But the darkness would not allow that.

Kraekon sighed. It had been over 4 years since he'd decided to stand against the dark, and yet he'd made no real progress. Sure, he was *technically* the head of Duskwatch now, but it was purely a technicality. The guard had been disbanded a couple months earlier, and nearly everyone had gone on to work other jobs instead. There were a few members who would answer his call if he asked, like Ivory, but it felt like he was all that was truly left of Duskwatch now.

Part of him wondered if he'd made the right decision, trying to keep it going. Without the city's backing, there wouldn't be enough guards to fight back if something happened. One person—well, a bit more with the handful he could round up at a moment's notice—couldn't hold back the dark. But he couldn't rest at night, knowing that *no one* was trying to protect the city. So Kraekon stayed, the solitary member and *de facto* leader of the now-volunteer organization Duskwatch.

Plus, this was all he really had left of his dad. Kraekon couldn't help but wonder if that factored into his reluctance to move on; training, even by himself, helped him feel closer to him—made it feel like he was still here, helping Kraekon get stronger. Regardless, he'd committed to keeping it going.

It wasn't easy. Duskwatch no longer put food on his table, but working another job would mean he couldn't be ready at a moment's notice. He'd still found a way to make ends meet, though: hauling cargo. Lots of people in the city needed heavy boxes moved; from reorganizing storage rooms to the distribution of food and goods, there was always a place for someone with a strong physique to help out.

Most of the time, he worked for Flavio, bringing goods to and from his shop. Flavio had always treated his family well, and he understood if Kraekon needed to take a break every once in a while to patrol the border or do some training. His second biggest employer was the farms, of course—they often had crates of food to send to the distributaries and other places. With all the places around town that he'd made deliveries to and from, he'd worked with all sorts of people.

Of course, his least favorite group to work for was arguably the most important one—the city council. Most of the council was tolerable—heck, a few of them were even pleasant to be around. But never was Kraekon's smile more strained than when Head Councilwoman Selia was around.

Maybe it was just personal bias; she'd frequently disrupted Ember's attempts at achieving their goals in the past, and more recently, she was personally responsible for disbanding Duskwatch. She'd labeled it—labeled *them*—a waste of resources. Duskwatch was scattered, and most of their supplies were confiscated and sent to Flavio to be melted into “more useful forms”. Or, maybe Selia was just a miserable person to be around. Either way, Kraekon dreaded running into her.

Despite his disdain for working for Selia, Kraekon still accepted the odd job for the council. They frequently had need of a strong individual to help out, and Kraekon figured that, if he was the one there, that maybe he could give the other members a more favorable view of Duskwatch.

Kraekon sighed as the rain came to a stop. He glanced over at the crate of food he'd been delivering when the rain started falling. It was probably fine, but he'd let the distributary know once he got there so they could check for signs of Shadowrot contamination. Hefting the massive crate over his head, he took off down the street once more.

As he finished up his last delivery of the day, Kraekon decided to stop by Flavio's shop before he went on a brief patrol for the night. He always felt like Flavio's store was a warm, inviting place, and it was one of the only shops where he could get his gear fixed up if he'd been training too much.

As luck would have it, today was a good day to visit. Flavio mentioned that he'd gotten a message from Ember and had planned to track Kraekon down after work, but now there was no need.

The message was simple.

“I did it. Tell Kraekon to grab someone he trusts and come to the lab.”

Kraekon broke into the most genuine smile he'd had in years. It was finally time, and he knew just who to grab.